

Lack of originality in the assessment

Frequently asked questions

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Lack of originality in the assessment

Frequently asked questions

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What is considered lack of originality?

Lack of originality in an exam, practical activity or Continuous Assessment Test (CAT) occurs when a student submission includes content that has not been created by the student on his/her own and its sources are not adequately cited. It also occurs when the sources of the external content have been identified, but its usage is so extensive that it is no longer possible to consider the student as the author of the submission.

Examples of potential lack of originality issues	
Inappropriate behavior	Remedy
A problem in a CAT has been solved collaboratively between several students.	Assessment activities should be solved individually.
A problem in a CAT uses information from Wikipedia without referencing the source.	Sources should always be cited: use the URL if this is an online resource or the bibliographic data if this is a paper or book. You can find a guide explaining how to reference your sources here: https://biblioteca.uoc.edu/en/contents/how-to-quote/index.html
A problem in a CAT quotes a short piece of text verbatim from Wikipedia. The source is referenced, but the text is not enclosed in quotation marks (“”).	When quoting verbatim, text should be enclosed in quotation marks: “This is a verbatim quote from an external source” [REFERENCE]
A problem in a CAT quotes a very large fragment verbatim from Wikipedia. The source is referenced and the text is enclosed in quotation marks.	External sources should not be quoted verbatim extensively. If this information is relevant, you should interpret it and present it using your own words, adapted to the context of the CAT and the problem. Nevertheless, it is still necessary to cite the sources that you have used to reach your conclusions.

What happens when a submission is not considered original?

If lack of originality is detected (the submissions of several students are too similar among them, or too similar to an external source - academic resource, Internet source, ...), there are several consequences:

- The activity where lack of originality was detected can be graded as “fail”. This grade may be assigned to the whole course. Finally, depending on the circumstances of the case, sanctions may be more severe (up to expulsion).

- The sanction may depend on whether this is the first time that lack of originality is detected in one of your submissions.
- **If it is the first time this happens, your name will be added to a registry of students involved in lack of originality sanctions.**

I have found the solution to a problem in CAT in a learning resource published in the classroom. Can I use that solution?

If you find the solution to any exercise in a CAT in a resource published in the classroom (academic materials, CATs or exams from previous semesters, ...) you can use the information you find there, but you must solve the activity on your own and describe your solution using your own words.

In the CAT, you will need to state that you have based your solution on that resource. If you quote any part verbatim, it should be enclosed in quotation marks. And remember that the amount of content that is quoted verbatim should not amount to more than 10% of the entire submission.

If you have any questions, please consult this issue with your course instructor.

I have found the solution to a problem in a CAT on the Internet. Can I use that solution?

If you find the solution to any exercise in a CAT on the Internet, you can use the information you find there, but you must solve the activity on your own and describe your solution using your own words.

In the CAT, you will need to state that you have based your solution on that resource. If you quote any part verbatim, it should be enclosed in quotation marks. And remember that the amount of content that is quoted verbatim should not amount to more than 10% of the entire submission.

If you have any questions, please consult this issue with your course instructor.

I belong to a study group. Can we solve the CAT collaboratively?

No. You can study together and practise solving exercises from previous semesters or other exercises that interest you. Nevertheless, each of you should solve the CAT individually.

Can I discuss the CAT with other people?

No. You can ask questions and discuss your opinions about the general concepts taught in the course, but not about the specific activities in the CAT. Some examples of behaviors that are inappropriate according to our academic standards are:

- Discuss which method should be used to solve an exercise
- Share part of the solution to an exercise
- Compare the solutions among different students
- Any discussion about the contents of the course where you clearly identify which exercise of a CAT you are referring to

If you have questions about the interpretation of the problem statement or you think you may have found an error, please contact your course instructor directly to ask about this issue.

I have a private teacher. Can I ask him/her to help me with the CAT?

No. You can ask for help to understand the general contents of the course. Nevertheless, you will need to solve the CAT on your own. If you need assistance, you can contact your course instructor, who will be glad to help.

Can I share my submission to the CAT with other people?

No. You cannot share your submission nor the problem statement of a CAT with anyone. If you need assistance, you can contact your course instructor, who will be glad to help.

Someone has asked me to share with him/her my solution to a CAT. What should I do?

We strongly recommend that you do not share your submission under any circumstance, even after the submission deadline. The person asking for this submission may have requested an extension to submit his CAT. This means he could use information about your proposed solution in his/her submission, and you could be accused of lack of originality.

Can I hire someone to help me solve a CAT?

No, you cannot hire anyone to help you solve a CAT. You will need to solve the CAT on your own. If you need assistance, you can contact your course instructor, who will be glad to help.

Does this FAQ apply only to the continuous assessment (CATs) or also to exams and other activities?

All answers to this FAQ apply both to continuous assessment tests (CATs) and any individual assessment activity (exams, practical activities, ...). For other types of activities (such as activities that involve teamwork), you should follow the instructions defined in the problem statement for that activity.

If UOC is committed to collaborative learning, why is it not possible to collaborate during the assessment activities?

We need to establish the difference between “learning” and “assessment process”.

- Learning within a course can be enriched through the questions and contributions from students and teaching staff. In this sense, UOC tries to promote collaboration within the learning process.
- On the other hand, the assessment process aims to measure the degree of acquisition of the competences for each student in the course. For this reason, assessment is performed individually, not collectively.

At UOC, the assessment process is continuous, so it is performed during the whole semester. In this way, the assessment process overlaps with the learning process. Nevertheless, we need to define clear boundaries between the two: even though they overlap, we learn as a group but we are assessed individually.

How does the lack of originality harm me?

The direct consequence of lack of originality is failing the activity where it is detected, the final mark for continuous assessment or practical activities, or the entire course. Moreover, there could be an academic sanction beyond the scope of the course, depending on the circumstances of your case. Furthermore, there are other consequences that harm you as well as other students:

- The loss of reputation for the degree you want to achieve and the university that will grant you this degree.
- The unfairness toward other students who are solving CATs individually.
- The teaching staff may be misled about the difficulty of an activity or the level of achievement within the class. This may cause them to be more strict when grading other students' submissions or to propose more complex activities during the remainder of the course.